

Effect of Illegitimate Tasks on Helping Behavior: the Role of Schadenfreude and Competition

ABSTRACT

Employees at workplace are often assigned with illegitimate tasks (ITs), which can influence them in various ways. Previous studies have primarily focused on the impacts of ITs on victims, largely neglecting third parties' perspectives. Drawing on social information processing theory (SIP), we propose that competition relationship can moderate the relationship between ITs and observer's schadenfreude and helping behavior. Moreover, in high-competition relationship, observed ITs are positively associated with observers' schadenfreude, leading to decreased helping behavior toward victims. In contrast, in low-competition relationship, observed ITs are not associated with observers' schadenfreude or helping behavior. Data from an experiment and a field study mainly support our hypotheses. We discuss the theoretical and practical implications of these findings and directions for future research.

Keywords:

Illegitimate tasks Schadenfreude Competition Helping behavior

INTRODUCTION

Employees at workplace sometimes engage in illegitimate tasks (ITs), which often fall outside the scope of their roles or should not be required at all (Semmer et al., 2010). ITs have been suggested to be an identity-threatening stressor and harmful to employee identity (e.g., Semmer et al., 2010, 2019). The existing literature has accumulated evidence regarding the ITs effect on the employee who are assigned these tasks (e.g., Eatough et al., 2016; Zhou, Eatough, & Wald, 2018).

Most research has focused on the outcomes of the employee of interest. Coworkers, as important stakeholders in the context of workplace ITs, have largely been overlooked. This omission may hamper us to gain a more comprehensive picture of the ITs phenomenon. It is crucial to examine the impact of ITs on third parties because ITs do not happen in isolation. In team settings, coworkers can directly or indirectly observe others' ITs. They may interpret the assignment in various ways, influencing their psychological state and behavior (Chiaburu & Harrison, 2008). Although observers are not assigned ITs, their experience of witnessing coworkers assigned with such tasks can prompt their certain evaluation (Skarlicki & Kulik, 2004). To address this deficit, our research focus is on the observers of ITs.

To date, most findings have shown that ITs are detrimental to employee emotional and mental health (Eatough et al., 2016; Semmer et al., 2015), work attitude (Apostel et al., 2018; Schmitt et al., 2015), and work-family facilitation (Ahmed et al., 2018). The behavioral consequence of ITs has been scarcely investigated. Helping behavior toward the employee of interest, defined as spontaneous actions focused on work-related issues (Podsakoff et al., 2000),

is particularly relevant in that it responds to perceiving others in trouble (O'Reilly & Aquino, 2011; Priesemuth & Schminke, 2019). Recent research has found that ITs were positively associated with colleagues' helping behavior because ITs triggered their sympathetic emotions (Wu, Ye, Liu, & Chen, 2024). However, not all workplace mistreatment engenders observers' helping behavior and even worse, they may reduce their aid to the victim (e.g., Gu et al., 2021; ul Haq et al., 2024). In a similar vein, we suspect that ITs may deteriorate colleagues' helping behavior since ITs assigned by the supervisor can act as social information to the victim's disadvantage. Social information processing (SIP) theory posits that individuals form their own perceptions and attitudes by observing and interpreting expressions and behaviors that reflect others' thoughts (i.e., social information, Salancik & Pfeffer, 1978). We believe that ITs assigned by supervisor can serve as significant social information that results in observers' negative reactions to ITs victims. Accordingly, our first objective is to examine the effect of ITs on the observer's emotion of *schadenfreude*, pleasure at the misfortunes of others (Smith et al., 1996; Spears et al., 2008), and helping behavior.

Our second objective is to examine the moderating role of interpersonal competition between the victim and observer in shaping the relationship between observing ITs and *schadenfreude*. SIP theory suggests that when processing social information, individuals tend to pay more attention to relevant cues, which refer to the degree to which the information's contents are related to their specific goals (Loi et al., 2012; Zalesny & Ford, 1990). Interpersonal competition, reflecting opposing interest against the other party (Watkins, 2021), can significantly affect individual goal achievement and how the events are evaluated. Moreover,

previous research has shown that an individual's emotional and behavioral response to the victim depends on their relationship with the victim (e.g., Blader et al., 2013; Mitchell et al., 2015). We therefore choose competition as a moderator in the relationship between ITs and observers' schadenfreude. Our conceptual model is shown in Figure 1.

 Insert Figure 1 about here

We aim to contribute to the literature in several ways. First, we provide a third-party perspective to elucidate the consequences of ITs at workplace. To our knowledge, except for Wu et al. (2024) study, existing studies have primarily focused on ITs effects on victims (e.g., Ahmed et al., 2018; Apostel et al., 2018; Eatough et al., 2016; Ma & Peng, 2019; Omansky et al., 2016; Schmitt et al., 2015; Semmer et al., 2015; Thun et al., 2018). Our research enriches the literature by examining how observing ITs leads to observers' emotion of schadenfreude and consequently their helping behavior toward the victim, with consideration of the mediating role of sympathy (Wu et al., 2024).

Second, drawing on the SIP theory, we extend the literature on ITs by examining the additional negative impact of ITs on the part of observer besides the harmful outcomes on the part of the victim. We argue that ITs assigned by the supervisor may signal important information regarding the supervisor's attitude to the victim and increase observers' emotion of schadenfreude, leading to decreased helping behavior towards the victim. Our view provides a different perspective to the relationship between ITs and observer's helping behavior from the recent one which has suggested witness of ITs increases helping behavior through sympathy (Wu

et al., 2024). Our research suggests the consequence of ITs may be worse off by decreasing observer's helping behavior apart from the emotional, attitudinal, and behavioral strain ITs cause for the victim.

By doing so, we also contribute to the leadership literature by revealing that ITs assignment may not only do harm to the ITs-bearer but also impair interpersonal relationship and group performance in that it exacerbates the bearer's situation by diminishing the aids he or she can get from colleagues otherwise.

Finally, this research contributes to the literature on competition by highlighting the role observer-bearer competition plays in shaping the effect of ITs on observer's schadenfreude. Our research enriches the literature by explaining how competitive relationship shapes observer's emotional response (i.e., schadenfreude) to ITs and consequently helping behavior toward the victims (Deutsch 1949). By integrating competition into the SIP framework, we provide an in-depth understanding of interpersonal dynamics in the context of ITs and show that highly competitive relationship can aggravate schadenfreude resulted from witness of ITs, diminishing helping behavior and possibly further decreasing collaboration among colleagues.

THEORETICAL DEVELOPMENT

Social Information Processing Theory (SIP)

SIP theory is grounded in the fundamental premise that “individuals, as adaptive organisms, adapt attitudes, behaviors, and beliefs to their social context” (Salancik & Pfeffer, 1978: 226). Individuals form their own perceptions and attitudes by observing and interpreting

expressions and behaviors that reflect others' thoughts (Salancik & Pfeffer, 1978). Considering the leaders' high status within an organization, their behaviors serve as significant information that influences their subordinates (Fehr et al., 2020; Zhu, 2020). As a result, in daily work, subordinates tend to construct and reconstruct their perceptions of reality by observing their supervisors' behaviors (Brass & Burkhardt, 1993). In other words, when leaders exhibit aggressive behavior, employees may subsequently behave aggressively as a result (Mitchell & Ambrose, 2012). Furthermore, previous research suggests that individuals tend to pay more attention to relevant information when processing social information, that is, information relevance, which refers to the degree to which the information's contents are related to individuals' goals (Loi et al., 2012; Zalesny & Ford, 1990).

Research identifies that certain work behaviors, such as helping behavior, information processing strategies, and probability judgments, are direct responses to affective experiences (Morris, 2012). According to SIP, observing others engaging in ITs at the workplace could trigger observers' negative reactions, which can impact helping behavior. Competition plays a pivotal role in how employees appraise the observed ITs. In highly competitive environments, employees often interpret the failures of others as victories for themselves (Deutsch, 1949). Consequently, employees who are highly competitive with each other tend to perceive ITs as relevant and beneficial to their own goals, resulting in heightened emotional discord with their peers. In contrast, those who exhibit low levels of competition tend to view ITs as relevant yet inconducive to their goals, unlikely to provoke *schadenfreude* with their coworkers.

Observed ITs, Schadenfreude, and Competition

When competition is relatively high, observed ITs are more likely to be perceived as promoting their own goals, leading to the emotion of schadenfreude (Smith, 2000).

Schadenfreude is a sense of pleasure derived from the misfortunes of others (Li et al., 2019). It encompasses both pleasure for one's own future superiority and contempt for the inferiority of others (Smith, 2000). This emotion arises from reactions to the misfortunes of others (Davis, 1983), illustrating the emotional dissonance between the observer and the victim (Chen et al., 2021). Prior research indicates that ITs are universally detrimental to their recipients (Semmer et al., 2015), positioning them as a form of subordinate misfortune in the workplace, which can elicit schadenfreude from observe towards the victim. Moreover, according to SIP, when leaders exhibit aggressive behavior, employees may accordingly behave aggressively (Mitchell & Ambrose, 2012). Therefore, ITs may elicit schadenfreude in observers.

We posit that observed ITs are more likely to generate schadenfreude when competition is high. According to SIP, employees tend to pay more attention to relevant information related to their goals (Loi et al., 2012). Their assessments of whether that event aids in achieving their goals largely influence the specific emotions they experience from it (Lazarus, 1991a; Weiss & Cropanzano, 1996). When an event is deemed conducive to individuals' goals, they are more likely to experience pleasure emotions. In contrast, if it is viewed as detrimental, anxiety emotions are likely to arise. With high competition, conflicting work goals and interest result in the perception that the success of one makes it less likely for the other to success (Chen &

Tjosvold, 2008), motivating interpersonal mistreatment (Kim & Glomb, 2014; Lam et al., 2011). When an individual observes a coworker being assigned ITs by their supervisor—indicative of the latter’s misfortune—they are more likely to see this task as advantageous for their own goals. Consequently, in high-competition contexts, observers tend to view their coworkers’ misfortunes as relevant to their own success, triggering feelings of *schadenfreude* (Smith, 2000). Furthermore, from a utilitarian perspective, the negative impact of ITs on coworkers may present opportunities for observers to gain material benefits, such as rewards or promotions, or to experience psychological superiority (Li et al., 2019), which can be significant motivators for *schadenfreude*.

Thus, when competition is high, observers are likely to evaluate the ITs assigned to their coworkers (i.e., others’ misfortune) as relevant and conducive to their own success, which triggers their *schadenfreude* (Smith, 2000). Contrariwise, when competition is relatively low, observed ITs are more likely to be interpreted as hindering their own goals, observers are less likely to evoke *schadenfreude* because they are less apt to treat the misfortunes of others as their own success (Wong et al., 2005). As explained above, an observer is more prone to experience *schadenfreude* in response to observed ITs when competition is high.

Hypothesis 1: Competition moderates the relationship between observed ITs and schadenfreude such that the relationship is positive when competition is high, but not significant when competition is low.

Observed ITs, Schadenfreude, and Helping Behavior

We propose that when observed ITs generate *schadenfreude*, they will prompt observers to

decrease helping behavior toward the victim. Helping behavior, characterized as spontaneous action focused on work-related issues, is a subcomponent of organizational citizenship behavior (Podsakoff et al., 2000). Emotion is an important factor influencing helping behavior (Morris, 2012). A positive emotional state is more likely to elicit helping behavior, whereas when emotions stem from benefits that contribute to goal achievement, individuals are less inclined to exhibit helping behavior (Chen et al., 2021; Cooper et al., 2018; Lin et al., 2019). Schadenfreude responds to the misfortunes of others, which is related to the achievement of one's own goals (Blader et al., 2010; Li et al., 2019). Observers who experience schadenfreude may be driven to inflict further harm, such as withholding assistance and valuable information from victims, or exhibiting increasing avoidance tendencies (Buss, 1961; Li et al., 2019; Neuman & Baron, 2005; Schindler et al., 2015). In addition, schadenfreude is a subtle, positive mood, motivating individuals to engage in behaviors to maintain or reinforce such emotion (Lazarus, 1991b; Li et al., 2019). Helping others not only depletes observers' resources, but alleviates others' pain in need (Koopman et al., 2016). Moreover, helping behavior is typically seen as discretionary (Organ, 2014), meaning that reducing assistance to coworkers is less likely to attract scrutiny or punishment within organizations (Chen et al., 2021). Consequently, to maintain this positive mood, observers are less likely to offer help (Chen et al., 2021). Extant studies support the idea that schadenfreude leads individuals to engage in less helping behavior (Chen et al., 2021; Li et al., 2019; Schindler et al., 2015; ul Haq et al., 2024).

Integrating these arguments, we propose that schadenfreude mediates the effects of observed ITs on helping behavior. Specifically, when employees witness others engaging in ITs,

they might fail to help those in misfortunes due to schadenfreude. Furthermore, because competition promotes schadenfreude, we accordingly predict that observed ITs are more likely to result in less helping behavior when competition is high, due to observers experiencing schadenfreude.

Hypothesis 2: The mediating effect of observed ITs on helping behavior through schadenfreude is moderated by competition, such that the relationship is negative when competition is high, but not significant when competition is low.

STUDY OVERVIEW

To test our theoretical model, we conducted two studies including one experimental study (i.e., Study 1) and one field study (i.e., Study 2). Using an experimental design, in Study 1, we provided causal evidence of observed ITs on helping behavior. Although Study 1 helped establish causal inferences for our theoretical model, its external validity is not ensured. Thus, to establish external validity, in Study 2, we tested our full model in a field setting (Hypothesis 1-2).

STUDY 1

Participants

We recruited 90 full-time working adults to participate in our study. They were told the purpose of the study and assured that participation was voluntary and anonymous, with each participant receiving 30 RMB as compensation. Among our participants, 50% were female, and 74.4% had a bachelor's degree.

Sample and Procedures

We adopted a single-factor between-subject design, randomly dividing the participants into

three groups: a legitimate tasks group and an illegitimate tasks group, with the latter further subdivided into an unreasonable tasks group and an unnecessary tasks group (Semmer et al., 2010). Participants were presented with three scenarios and imagined they were junior physicians in a large complex hospital integrating medical treatment, scientific research, and teaching. Specifically, in each scenario, participants were invited to read a general paragraph describing their primary duties and the relationship between them and their coworker—Dr. Zhang.

Observed illegitimate tasks manipulation Based on previous research, scholars have pointed out that the two types of ITs, unreasonable tasks and unnecessary tasks, may lead to different outcomes (Sonnentag & Lischetzke, 2018). Therefore, we separately examined these two types of ITs. Participants were presented with the scenario:

a: Legitimate Tasks Group: You and Dr. Zhang are junior physicians who joined the hospital simultaneously. There exists both cooperation and competition in your daily encounters. The job description clearly states that your primary duties are: to carry out work under the guidance of the department head and attending physician, handle the medical treatment of a certain number of patients, including conducting examinations, making diagnoses, and providing treatments, and to promptly inform the attending physician of any changes in the patient's condition. In your daily work, you often hear the attending physician assign tasks to Dr. Zhang in this manner: "First, get to know the patient's basic medical history and record it in the medical record; then, accompany me on an outpatient clinic visit; and finally, conduct a preliminary examination for this patient and write up the case report."

b: Unreasonable Tasks Group: You and Dr. Zhang are junior physicians who joined the hospital simultaneously. There exists both cooperation and competition in your daily encounters. The job description clearly states that your primary duties are: to carry out work under the guidance of the department head and attending physician, handle the medical treatment of a certain number of patients, including conducting examinations, making diagnoses, and providing treatments, and to promptly inform the attending physician of any changes in the patient's condition. One day, while you and Dr. Zhang are filling out medical records, the attending physician calls Dr. Zhang over and says, "Put down your current work for a moment. The reception desk has notified us that there are too many patients today and they are overwhelmed. You need to go help out as a guide (i.e., only need to guide patients to register and direct them to the relevant departments for treatment, without requiring medical skills) for the day, guiding and receiving patients."

c: Unnecessary Tasks Group: You and Dr. Zhang are junior physicians who joined the hospital simultaneously. There exists both cooperation and competition in your daily encounters. The job description clearly states that your primary duties are: to carry out work under the guidance of the department head and attending physician, handle the medical treatment of a certain number of patients, including conducting examinations, making diagnoses, and providing treatments, and to promptly inform the attending physician of any changes in the patient's condition. On a regular day, the attending physician would ask you to copy some patients' medical records from the computer to a USB drive. One day, when Dr. Zhang brings the medical records copied onto a USB drive to the attending physician, you overhear the attending physician say to Dr. Zhang, "Why did you copy it to a USB drive? I prefer using floppy disks. You need to immediately copy these records onto a floppy disk and bring it back to me!" Dr.

Zhang mutters under his breath, “Whether it’s a USB drive or a floppy disk, the medical records inside are the same. Why do I have to redo it? Switching to a floppy disk means going through the whole process again to apply from the department...”

Measures

We used translation and back translation to minimize translation errors. Unless otherwise noted, participants responded using a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 “strongly disagree” to 5 “strongly agree” for the two studies. All the scales have been validated in previous studies conducted in a Chinese context.

Schadenfreude We used the four-item scale adapted from Leach et al. (2003) to measure schadenfreude. A sample item was “I feel a little relieved about what happened to him/her” ($\alpha = 0.85$).

Helping behavior We used the six-item scale adapted from Settoon and Mossholder (2002) to measure helping behavior. A sample item was “When he/she falls behind on his/her work, I am willing to help him/her cope with the status quo” ($\alpha = 0.91$).

Control variables We controlled for sympathy, as prior research has highlighted its importance (Wu et al., 2024). Sympathy was measured using a three-item scale adapted from Davis (1983) and Pfattheicher et al. (2019). A sample item was “As a fellow junior physician, I feel sympathy for his/her experience” ($\alpha = 0.92$).

Manipulation check measure At the end of the experiment, we asked participants to rate the extent to which the supervisor assigned their coworker ITs using a four-item scale adapted

from Wald (2022). A sample item was “He/she was assigned tasks that involve less advanced knowledge and skills than should be expected of him/her” ($\alpha = 0.88$).

Results

Manipulation checks T-test results found that the mean of the experimental condition of observed unreasonable tasks ($M = 4.35$, $SD = 0.72$) was significantly higher than that of the control condition ($M = 2.68$, $SD = 1.21$), with $t(58) = -6.49$, $p < 0.001$. Also, the mean of the experimental condition of observed unnecessary tasks ($M = 4.28$, $SD = 0.81$) was significantly higher than that of the control condition ($M = 1.90$, $SD = 1.19$), with $t(58) = -9.07$, $p < 0.001$. These results indicate that the manipulation of observed ITs was effective.

Hypothesis testing We conducted an ANOVA analysis to test the main effect. Table 1 indicated that participants in the observed unreasonable tasks condition ($M = 3.20$, $SD = 0.75$) and unnecessary tasks condition ($M = 2.97$, $SD = 0.79$) reported higher levels of schadenfreude than those in the control condition ($M = 2.53$, $SD = 0.67$), $F(2, 87) = 6.52$, $p < 0.05$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.15$. We next utilized bootstrapping to test the mediating role of schadenfreude on the relationship between observed ITs and helping behavior. Table 2 reports the results of mediation effect tests. The bootstrapping results revealed that the mediating effect of the observed unreasonable tasks on observers’ helping behavior toward victims via observers’ schadenfreude was significant (estimate = -0.44 , $SE = 0.14$, 95% CI $[-0.73, -0.20]$). The mediating effect of observed unnecessary tasks on helping behavior through schadenfreude was also significant (estimate = -0.29 , $SE = 0.12$, 95% CI $[-0.53, -0.04]$).

 Insert Table 1 and Table 2 about here

STUDY 2

Sample and Procedures

We collected data from an IT company in Eastern China and obtained data from employees and their immediate supervisors using online survey. Before distributing the questionnaires, the HR department provided us with employees' emails and team membership information, which was used to match observer-victim. We invited 426 employees from 59 teams to participate in the survey and sent emails to the respondents in advance assuring them that their data would be kept anonymous and confidential. The survey was conducted at three time points. At Time 1, employees rated observed ITs and competition of all their colleagues in the same group, and personal information. Two days after Time 1 (i.e., Time 2), employees rated their feeling of schadenfreude towards colleagues. Two weeks at Time 3, victims rated helping behavior they received from colleagues. Since we need a network data to test our model, any missing data from either side of the dyad could not be included. Our final sample consists of 183 employees (73% response rate) in 38 groups. The gender distribution in the company is relatively balanced, with a slight majority of females (55.7%). The average age of the sample was 42.1 years and the majority of responding employees have a junior college degree (34.4%).

Measures

Observed illegitimate tasks In this study, we utilized the eight-item scale adapted from Semmer et al. (2010) and Wald (2022) for measuring observed ITs. A sample item was "He/she

was assigned tasks that are not within his or her scope of responsibilities” ($\alpha = 0.96$).

Competition In this study, competition was measured using a three-item scale based on Kilduff et al. (2010) and Xu et al. (2020). Participants were asked to indicate to what extent they consider colleagues assigned ITs to be their competitors. A sample item was “He/she is my rival in terms of performance” ($\alpha = 0.91$).

Schadenfreude We measured schadenfreude using the same scale as in Study 1 ($\alpha = 0.84$).

Helping behavior We measured helping behavior using the same scale as in Study 1 ($\alpha = 0.97$).

Control variables We controlled for sympathy and used the same scale as in Study 1 ($\alpha = 0.87$). In addition, we controlled for demographic variables such as gender, age, highest education level and years of work experience were controlled for, as past research has shown their significant impact on employees’ perceptions of ITs.

Analytic strategy

Our study utilized two statistical packages, SPSS 25.0 and AMOS 24.0, for data analysis. We began with conducting confirmatory factor analyses (CFAs) using AMOS 24.0. Following this, we used SPSS 25.0 for descriptive and correlation analysis of the study variables. To thoroughly examine the outcomes of our research model, we again utilized SPSS 25.0. Finally, to evaluate the moderated mediation hypotheses (Hypothesis 2), we implemented bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples, using SPSS 25.0 for these computations.

Results

Preliminary Analysis Table 3 displays the CFAs result. The hypothesized five-factor model provided a good fit to the data ($\chi^2/df = 1.71$, CFI = 0.96, IFI = 0.96, RMSEA = 0.06, SRMR =

0.04) and was better than any of the four-factor models (see Table 3). These results provided evidence of the construct validity of the five-factor model.

Insert Table 3 about here

Hypothesis Testing Table 4 reports descriptive statistics and correlations. As shown, schadenfreude was negatively related to helping behavior, aligning with our expectations. Additionally, a significant relationship between ITs and sympathy was found, consistent with previous research (Wu et al., 2024). Table 5 displays the results of regression analyses for testing Hypothesis 1. To test Hypothesis 1, and as shown in Model 4 of Table 5, the moderation effect of competition on the relationship between observed ITs and schadenfreude was significant ($b = 0.14$, $SE = 0.05$, $p < 0.01$). As depicted in Figure 2, when competition was low, there was no effect of observed ITs on schadenfreude (simple slope = -0.04 , ns). However, when competition was high, there was a significant positive effect of observed ITs on schadenfreude (simple slope = 0.30 , $p < 0.001$). These results supported Hypothesis 1.

Insert Table 4, Table 5, and Figure 2 about here

Next, we used bootstrapping to examined Hypothesis 2. Hypothesis 2 proposed that the mediating effect of observed ITs on helping behavior through schadenfreude is stronger when competition is high. As shown in Table 6, the bootstrapping results revealed that observed ITs had a negative indirect effect on helping behavior via observers' schadenfreude when competition was high (estimate = -0.08 , $SE = 0.04$, 95% CI [-0.19 , -0.01]), but it was not significant when competition was low (estimate = 0.05 , $SE = 0.04$, 95% CI [-0.01 , 0.15]). The 95

percent confidence interval in the difference of these effects excluded zero (difference = -0.06, SE = 0.03, 95% CI [-0.13, -0.02]), supporting Hypothesis 2.

 Insert Table 6 about here

GENERAL DISCUSSION

To date, prior studies have primarily focused on the impacts of ITs on the victims, while the perspective of third parties has been neglected. Drawing on SIP, we aim to develop a comprehensive understanding of the consequences of employees engaging in ITs. Specifically, we examine the process through which observed ITs triggers observers' schadenfreude, which can hinder helping behavior. Interestingly, we demonstrate that when competition is high, observers are more susceptible to schadenfreude and a reduction in helping behavior. However, when competition is low, there is no significant effect between observed ITs with helping behavior via schadenfreude.

Theoretical Implications

Our research offers several theoretical contributions. First, it enhances the literature on illegitimate tasks by incorporating the observer's perspective. Existing models have primarily only theorized the impact of ITs on victims (e.g., Ahmed et al., 2018; Apostel et al., 2018; Eatough et al., 2016; Schmitt et al., 2015; Semmer et al., 2015; Thun et al., 2018). We contend that observed ITs are also meaningful to observers, and a complete understanding of the effects of ITs requires consideration of distinct observer-based consequences. We argue that observed ITs significantly impact observers, eliciting schadenfreude and decreased helping behavior. As

such, we contribute to the literature by theorizing the reactions of observers in relation to victims.

Second, our research broadens the literature on ITs by examining the additional negative impact of ITs. Based on SIP, we contend that ITs assigned by the supervisor may convey aggressive signals towards the victim, thereby intensifying observers' schadenfreude and subsequently reducing their willingness to help. Our research suggests that the consequences of ITs may be even more detrimental by further diminishing observers' helping behavior. We thus contribute to the ITs literature by revealing that ITs assignment may not only do harm to the ITs-bearer but also impair interpersonal relationship and group performance.

Third, this research contributes to ITs literature by extending the empirical investigation of the emotional mechanisms involved. Drawing on SIP, our research introduces the effects of schadenfreude within the context of observed ITs. From an emotional perspective, this research responds to previous studies (Semmer et al., 2015), offering novel insights and theoretical foundations for future theoretical investigations and practical applications concerning ITs.

Finally, our findings make a significant contribution to the theory of cooperation and competition. By highlighting how competition influences observers' emotional responses to ITs, we shed light on the dynamics between competitive and cooperative behaviors in organizational settings. Specifically, the tendency for observers to exhibit schadenfreude based on competitive contexts suggests that the social environment plays a crucial role in shaping interpersonal relationships and dynamics among employees. This nuanced understanding can inform strategies for preventing the reduction of helping in competitive workplaces, ultimately leading to a more

harmonious and productive organizational culture.

Practical Implications

In addition to our theoretical contributions, our findings provide several practical insights. Research on ITs suggests that leaders should avoid assigning such tasks to employees (Grotto & Mills, 2023). Since observed ITs can influence the helping behavior of observers, leaders can benefit from identifying cues of ITs through the helping behavior exhibited by these observers. In addition, our findings indicate that in highly competitive environments, engaging in ITs may lead to a decline in helping behavior. This suggests that competition imposes previously unrecognized costs on employees (Watkins, 2021). Therefore, leaders should minimize competition in order to prevent employees from engaging in ITs that contribute negatively to the organization. For example, managers could enhance human resource allocation, optimize performance appraisal system and refine salary management system to prevent unhealthy competition and its detrimental effects.

Limitations and Future Directions

Despite the strengths of our study 1 and study 2, certain limitations should be acknowledged. Study 1 provided the causal evidence, while Study 2 explored the boundary conditions of these relationships. We encourage researchers to further examine and replicate these moderating effects in experimental settings. In addition, drawing on SIP, we only examined *schadenfreude* as mediator between observed ITs and observers' helping behavior. However, observed ITs may also trigger other reactions, such as envy, silence, or punishment. Different attribution styles could influence how observers react to victims. Future research should aim to broaden our model

by incorporating these mediating effects. Furthermore, while our focus was on observers' reactions to victims, it would be valuable for future studies to investigate managers' reactions as well. Given the differing perceptions of ITs between managers and employees (Meier & Semmer, 2018), these discrepancies may provoke negative emotional responses among employees. Incorporating managers' reactions into our model could yield varied outcomes related to ITs.

CONCLUSION

Although the majority of research has concentrated on the negative impact of ITs on the employees directly involved, our study highlights how observers react to victims, triggering behaviors that influence the organization. Grounded in SIP, results from two studies indicated that observers can feel schadenfreude, which decreases their helping behavior, especially in high-competitive environments. We hope that our research inspires a new perspective on ITs and encourages future investigation into how such tasks affect workgroups and organizations.

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Table 1

The Analysis of variance of schadenfreude and sympathy under different task scenarios

Task category	Schadenfreude		Sympathy	
	M	SD	M	SD
Legitimate tasks	2.53	0.67	1.99	0.92
Unreasonable tasks	3.20	0.75	4.01	0.90
Unnecessary tasks	2.97	0.79	4.27	0.41
F	6.52 **		76.73 **	
Post Hoc Comparisons	1 < 2**, 1<3*		1 < 2 **, 1<3 **	

Note: *p < 0.05, **p < 0.01, 1 = Legitimate tasks, 2 = Unreasonable tasks, 3 = Unnecessary tasks.

Table 2

The test of the mediating effect of schadenfreude and sympathy on helping behavior

Path	Estimate	SE	Boot95%CI
With the control group as a reference			
Unreasonable tasks → Schadenfreude → Helping behavior	-0.44 ^a	0.14	[-0.73, -0.20]
Unreasonable tasks → Sympathy → Helping behavior	0.89 ^a	0.21	[0.50, 1.30]
Unreasonable tasks → Helping behavior	-0.10	0.22	[-0.54, 0.34]
Unnecessary tasks → Schadenfreude → Helping behavior	-0.29 ^a	0.12	[-0.53, -0.04]
Unnecessary tasks → Sympathy → Helping behavior	1.01 ^a	0.24	[0.53, 1.48]
Unnecessary tasks → Helping behavior	-0.37	0.23	[-0.82, 0.09]

Note: a represents a significant mediation effect.

Table 3*Confirmatory factor analysis results*

	χ^2/df	CFI	IFI	RMSEA	SRMR
Five-Factor model	1.71	0.96	0.96	0.06	0.04
Four-Factor model	2.84	0.89	0.89	0.10	0.11
Three-factor model	3.88	0.82	0.82	0.13	0.15
Two-factor model	5.04	0.75	0.75	0.15	0.16
One-factor model	10.09	0.44	0.44	0.22	0.25

Notes:

Five-Factor model: Illegitimate tasks; Schadenfreude; Sympathy; Competition; Helping behavior.

Four-Factor model: Illegitimate tasks; Schadenfreude + Sympathy; Competition; Helping behavior.

Three-factor model: Illegitimate tasks + Schadenfreude + Sympathy; Competition; Helping behavior.

Two-factor model: Illegitimate tasks; Schadenfreude + Sympathy + Competition + Helping behavior.

One-factor model: Illegitimate tasks + Schadenfreude + Sympathy + Competition + Helping behavior.

Table 4*Descriptive statistical analysis results and correlation coefficient matrix*

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Gender	0.44	0.50	1.00								
2. Age	42.10	7.26	0.02	1.00							
3. Education	2.72	1.14	0.05	-0.46**	1.00						
4. Work Tenure	6.08	6.28	0.02	0.21**	-0.05	1.00					
5. Illegitimate tasks	2.39	1.08	0.07	0.06	0.06	0.07	1.00				
6. Competition	3.30	1.18	-0.17*	-0.13	0.02	-0.11	-0.17*	1.00			
7. Schadenfreude	2.23	0.93	0.08	0.15*	-0.16*	0.09	0.04	-0.19**	1.00		
8. Sympathy	3.19	1.04	0.16*	0.00	0.03	0.06	0.46**	-0.21**	-0.08	1.00	
9. Helping behavior	3.24	1.05	0.00	-0.11	0.11	0.19**	-0.03	0.12	-0.38**	0.12	1.00

Note: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Table 5*Regression analysis of main effect and moderating effect*

Variables	Schadenfreude				Sympathy			
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6	Model 7	Model 8
Gender	0.01 (.14)	-0.00 (.14)	-0.00 (.14)	0.00 (.14)	0.34* (.16)	0.28* (.14)	0.24 (.14)	0.24 (.14)
Age	0.00 (.01)	0.00 (.01)	0.00 (.01)	0.00 (.01)	-0.00 (.01)	-0.01 (.01)	-0.01 (.01)	-0.01 (.01)
Education	-0.04 (.07)	-0.05 (.07)	-0.05 (.07)	-0.04 (.07)	0.02 (.08)	-0.02 (.07)	-0.02 (.07)	-0.02 (.07)
Dyadic Tenure	0.02 (.01)	0.02 (.01)	0.02 (.01)	0.02 (.01)	0.01 (.01)	0.01 (.01)	0.01 (.01)	0.01 (.01)
Illegitimate tasks		0.11 (.06)	0.10 (.06)	0.13 (.06)		0.44*** (.06)	0.42*** (.07)	0.40*** (.07)
Competition			-0.00 (.06)	-0.01 (.06)			-0.10 (.06)	-0.10 (.06)
Illegitimate tasks× Competition				0.14** (.05)				-0.11* (.05)
R^2	0.02	0.03	0.03	0.08	0.03	0.23	0.24	0.26
ΔR^2	0.02	0.02	0.00	0.04**	0.03	0.20***	0.01	0.02*

Note: N = 183. Model reflects unstandardized regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 6*The Results of Moderated mediation effect test*

Variables	Competition	Estimate	SE	Boot95%CI
Schadenfreude	M-1SD	0.05	0.04	[-0.01, 0.15]
	M+1SD	-0.08	0.04	[-0.19, -0.01]
	Between-group difference (high-low)	-0.06	0.03	[-0.13, -0.02]
Sympathy	M-1SD	0.06	0.04	[-0.02, 0.16]
	M+1SD	0.03	0.03	[-0.01, 0.11]
	Between-group difference (high-low)	-0.01	0.01	[-0.05, 0.00]

Note: N = 183, bootstrap = 5000, CI = Confidence interval

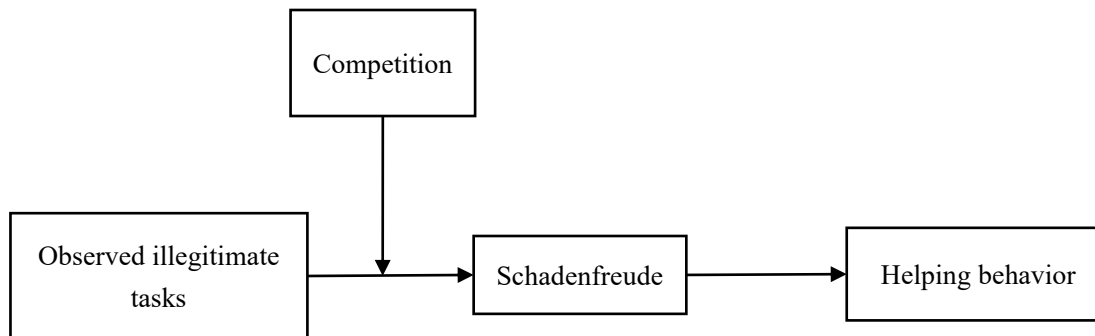
Figure 1*Theory Model*

Figure 2

The Moderating Effect of Competition on “Observed Illegitimate Tasks-Schadenfreude”

